

Choose the Stronger Argument

Study Guide - Extended Response

1. Learning goal

Choose the better-supported source by comparing relevance, sufficiency, reasoning, credibility, and limitations.

2. What this skill means

The stronger argument is not the louder or more confident one. It is the source whose evidence actually fits its claim, whose reasoning connects evidence to recommendation, and whose conclusion matches the limits of the evidence.

3. Do not confuse it with

A valid concern is not automatically a strong argument. A source can raise a real risk but still be weaker if it does not show the risk occurred or outweighs measured results.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask which argument is better supported, which source is more convincing, or which evidence most strengthens or weakens a position.

5. Repeatable method

- Test relevance: does the evidence measure the claimed issue?
- Test sufficiency: is there enough support for the size of the conclusion?
- Test reasoning: does the conclusion actually follow?
- Test credibility and limitations: is the source fair about uncertainty?
- Compare both sides using the same standards, then choose.

6. Worked example

Source A gives pilot results, cost data, and a limited expansion plan. Source B predicts vandalism but gives no repair records.

Question: Which source is stronger?

Reasoning: Source A directly measures the program and matches its recommendation to the evidence. Source B raises a possible risk without showing that it happened.

Best answer: Source A is better supported.

7. Common traps

- Counting the number of statistics instead of checking relevance.
- Assuming a cautious tone means a cautious argument is stronger.
- Rejecting a source because it admits a limitation.
- Calling the weaker source completely wrong instead of identifying the support gap.

8. Diagnostic help

- If both sources feel equal, compare the single strongest evidence item from each.
- If you keep choosing the more confident writer, hide the recommendation and judge the evidence first.
- If you write "has more facts," specify what those facts actually prove.

9. Quick check

Source A reports measured outcomes from the exact program being debated. Source B relies on two possible problems that were not measured.

Which has the stronger support and why?

Check yourself: Source A, because its evidence directly tests the program outcomes.